

Australia Daily Brief

Monday, October 5, 2026

2,220 words · 9 min read

RE: Fiji sets Dec 9 referendum, suspends campaigning · NZ declines Canada-led Defence Bank · Samoa PM apologises for 2007 Nazi salute · Pre-COP31 opens in Nadi with Australia's coal under fire · Albanese to Tuvalu Tuesday

ASX 200

8,686

+0.08%

AUD/USD

0.6962

-0.77%

NZX 50

13,699

-0.95%

NZD/USD

0.5595

-1.22%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's Rabuka set December 9 for the country's first constitutional referendum and asked the Electoral Commission to suspend general election campaigning, with a general election still constitutionally due by February 5.
- 2 New Zealand told Ottawa in late August it would not join the Canada-led Defence, Security and Resilience Bank, declining an initial \$100 million contribution flagged by MFAT officials.
- 3 Pacific delegations opened Pre-COP31 in Nadi by pressing Australia, the COP31 negotiations president, over its approval of a coal mine expansion, with Albanese and Pacific leaders due in Tuvalu on Tuesday.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji sets December 9 referendum, moves to suspend election campaigning

Sitiveni Rabuka named Wednesday, December 9 as the date for Fiji's first constitutional referendum and wrote to the Electoral Commission asking it to suspend all general election campaigning. Parliament passed the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 on Friday, with only five MPs voting against; the bill now enters a 30-day public consultation before a third reading on November 2. Proposed changes include a Senate, a mixed electoral system, and the removal of immunity for those involved in coups. Rabuka said the general election must be held before February 5.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji schedules potential referendum date on new constitution ahead of final parliament vote" · also Fiji Sun

NZ-DEFENSE

New Zealand declines Canada-led Defence, Security and Resilience Bank

Officials advised against joining the Defence, Security and Resilience Bank in late July, and the decision was communicated to Ottawa in late August, documents released under the Official Information Act show. Canadian Prime Minister **Mark Carney** invited **Christopher Luxon** in late April to negotiate the bank's charter and eventually buy in; MFAT flagged an initial *\$100 million* contribution plus ongoing governance costs. Committed members include Ukraine and Turkey. New Zealand is separately lifting defence spending to 2 percent of GDP, or \$12 billion, over eight years.

per RNZ: "New Zealand walks away from multi-billion dollar Defence Bank"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Samoa's prime minister apologises for 2007 Nazi salute video

La'aulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt apologised on Monday after the Samoa Observer published a seven-second clip, filmed at a family reunion in Safotu, Savai'i in July 2007, showing him leading about 13 people in a raised-arm salute and the words "Heil Hitler." He said the words and gesture were "inappropriate and capable of causing offence and hurt" and that he rejects "Nazism, antisemitism, racism and all forms of political extremism." Schmidt was deputy speaker of parliament at the time and has led Samoa since the August 2025 election.

per RNZ Pacific: "Samoan PM La'aulialemalietoa apologises for historical 'Heil Hitler' video" · also ABC News, Samoa Observer

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Australia's coal expansion draws Pacific fire as Pre-COP31 opens in Nadi

Pacific governments used the opening of the four-day Pre-COP31 meeting to challenge Australia, the lead negotiator and main funder of the talks, over its approval of a major coal mine expansion. Fiji's permanent secretary for environment and climate change **Sivendra Michael** said Australia "should be here to listen to the Pacific partners" and honour the 1.5-degree guardrail, adding that the New South Wales mine decision was a matter for Australian environmental law. In Nabavatu, declared unsafe in 2021, **Marica Malumuca** has lived in a tent for *five years*.

per ABC News: "Australia's fossil fuel expansion 'slap in the face' to Pacific nations" · also Fiji Sun

• OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

[Taylor to cut migration by two-thirds in bid to rival One Nation](#) · SMH

Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** will propose cutting the migration intake by *two thirds*, with international students forced to go offshore to apply for another visa. The Sydney Morning Herald reports the change could push temporary migrants to leave Australia. The policy is framed as a response to One Nation's rising support, which has reshaped Coalition positioning ahead of the Victorian state poll in November.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[HRW accuses Canberra of 'outsourcing' responsibility for Australians in Iraqi jails](#) · ABC News

Human Rights Watch says *13 Australians* held in Iraqi jails on suspicion of Islamic State links face inhumane treatment and potential execution, and accused the **Albanese** government of "outsourcing" its responsibilities. The men were among almost 5,700 transferred to Iraq from Syria by the United States military earlier this year. Iraqi authorities have asked for greater support and called on Australia to take the men back; the government declined to comment on legal and security grounds.

AU-POLITICS

[Flydubai co-pilot studied in Melbourne and visited radical mosques, reports say](#) · Reuters

Australian police confirmed they are investigating the flydubai co-pilot's links to Australia after the alleged cockpit attack. The Australian Financial Review reported he visited radical mosques while in the country, Bloomberg reported he was a failed student at an Australian university, and The Australian published details of a confidential RMIT University email on his studies. Recriminations are growing between governments over the security failures that preceded the attempted hijacking.

AU-POLITICS

[Gillard and Ardern named as COP31 speakers amid row over invitations](#) · The Australian

Julia Gillard and Jacinda Ardern are among the speakers lined up by Climate Change and Energy Minister **Chris Bowen** for pre-COP events, The Australian reported, as the government faces demands over how the guest list was assembled. The paper's commentary pages dismissed the line-up as "an F-team." Only the leaders of Antigua and Barbuda, Cabo Verde, Thailand, the Maldives, and Timor-Leste have confirmed attendance in Fiji.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Bank of America warns Australian super funds on rate levels](#) · ABC News

Bank of America's head of interest rates strategy **Mark Cabana**, a former New York Federal Reserve analyst, told Australian superannuation funds that borrowing costs are approaching levels that would damage the economy and retirement savings. He said rates are still "not restrictive" enough. The Federal Reserve recently raised its benchmark a quarter point to between 3.75 and 4 percent; low productivity, excess demand, the AI boom, and the Iran war are pushing yields higher.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

[Vanuatu condemns New Caledonian lawmaker's 'neo-colonial rant'](#) · RNZ Pacific

Vanuatu's government condemned what it called a "shameful, racist, and neo-colonial rant" by a pro-France New Caledonian lawmaker who mocked the island nation, declaring "we are not a French province." The exchange followed Vanuatu's statement to the UN General Assembly on September 28 on its International Court of Justice application over two uninhabited islands east of New Caledonia.

• STAT OF THE DAY

4,000

delegates expected in Nadi for Pre-COP31

Only five leaders from outside the Pacific have confirmed attendance, leaving officials to carry the message home.

ABC Pacific

• PACIFIC WIRE

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Vanuatu's ICJ claim over Matthew and Hunter inflames New Caledonian politics

Vanuatu's Permanent Representative to the UN, Ambassador **Odo Tevi**, told the General Assembly on September 28 that Umaenupne (Matthew) and Umaeneag (Hunter) are "an integral part of Vanuatu's territory," grounded in customary governance and indigenous ownership, and confirmed an ICJ application. **Nicolas Metzendorf**, one of two New Caledonian deputies in the French National Assembly, responded with an open letter to Prime Minister **Jotham Napat**.

TUVALU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tuvalu hosts leaders' event as more than 50 countries gather in Fiji

Fiji and Australia co-host the Pacific Pre-COP from October 5 to 8, with a separate leaders' event in Tuvalu on October 5 and 6. Climate Change and Environment Minister **Maina Vakafua Talia** said Tuvalu averages two metres above sea level and that outcomes from the two meetings "must help drive stronger ambition and action now." Agenda items include energy, climate finance access, and ocean protection.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

Solomons minister calls regional solidarity a 'strategic necessity'

Environment Minister **Wayne Ghemu** told a briefing hosted by the Pacific Regional Environment Programme and the Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat that "regional solidarity is not simply a matter of convenience; it is a strategic necessity." Prime Minister **Matthew Vale**, who arrived in Fiji at the weekend, confirmed the aim of taking visiting delegations to Tuvalu's low-lying atolls, saying organisers hope it will be high tide.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Marape offers Tuvalu partnership on reclamation and water security

Prime Minister **James Marape** said Papua New Guinea is ready to work with Tuvalu on long-term climate responses including land reclamation, coastal protection, water security, renewable energy, and fisheries development. The offer lands as Pacific leaders assemble for the Tuvalu leaders' event, and positions Port Moresby as a south-south partner rather than a recipient in the climate conversation.

TIMOR-LESTE · ABC PACIFIC

Timor-Leste among only five non-Pacific leaders confirmed for Nadi

About 4,000 people are expected in Nadi this week, but only the leaders of Antigua and Barbuda, Cabo Verde, Thailand, the Maldives, and Timor-Leste have confirmed attendance from outside the Pacific. **Sitiveni Rabuka** said delegates would still carry what they see back to their heads of state, listing damage caused by climate change, Fiji's mitigation work, and assistance needs as his three objectives.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

PINA backs Samoan journalists after reporter's photographs deleted

The Pacific Islands News Association, in a statement approved by President **Neville Choi**, said the deletion of a Samoa Observer reporter's photographs by the prime minister's son at a public police event was "concerning to PINA." The incident occurred during Police Remembrance Day at the Government Building in Eleele Fou on September 29. PINA backed the Journalists Association of Samoa's call for the circumstances to be established.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

COP31 president-designate tells Nadi: 'We are here to listen to the Pacific'

Türkiye's Minister of Environment, Urbanisation and Climate Change **Murat Kurum** pledged to fight "with all our strength" to prevent Pacific families losing their homes, speaking at the Vale ni Vanua knowledge exchange in Denarau. He described Antalya as an "implementation" summit with 10 themes and six global goals for 2035, and said he made the commitment jointly with Australia's **Chris Bowen**.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Tabuya says climate finance 'not flowing at the speed or scale required'

Environment and Climate Change Minister **Lynda Tabuya** told about 650 people in Denarau that finance is not flowing fast enough and that 1.5°C overshoot is imminent. She asked communities to document how long they

waited for seawalls, water systems, and solar minigrids, calling those accounts "the evidence Fiji will carry into the ministerial discussions on access to finance on Thursday."

NIUE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Niue Ocean Wide Trust named an Earthshot Prize 2026 finalist

The Niue Ocean Wide Trust is one of 15 finalists for the Earthshot Prize 2026, in the Revive Our Oceans category. The trust supports management of more than *300,000 square kilometres* of marine territory, including the Niue Moana Mahu Marine Protected Area, which covers about 40 percent of Niue's exclusive economic zone, using ocean finance to keep returns with island communities.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · NZ HERALD

Who holds foreign affairs after the election becomes a coalition question

The NZ Herald examines who would take the foreign affairs portfolio if **Winston Peters** does not, noting that when The Opportunities Party set out five bottom lines last week the portfolio question was not among them. Leader **Qiulae Wong** has previously staked out a position on it. The portfolio has repeatedly been a coalition bargaining chip, and New Zealanders vote on November 7.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

KPMG ban leaves room for \$38.5 million to keep flowing

Politico reports the Australian ban on new KPMG contracts still allows *\$38.5 million* to reach the firm. The Australian separately put Commonwealth consultant spending at a record \$860 million, with KPMG contracts surging to \$59 million, and argued KPMG Australia may have a case for support from its global headquarters.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Neo-Nazi gains entry to One Nation's Victorian election launch

A neo-Nazi gained entry to One Nation's Victorian election launch, The Australian reported. The paper also reported that Gina Rinehart bought an *\$8 million* Brisbane building to house a new One Nation headquarters, adding to earlier support including flights and use of a jet. The party's rise is driving Coalition policy repositioning on migration.

US-AUSTRALIA · AFR

Truth Social carries AI-generated scam ads aimed at Australians

Australian politicians criticised the prevalence of AI-generated scam advertising targeting Australians on Truth Social, the social media platform owned by the US president. The Australian Financial Review reports the content is widespread on the site.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Banks lift fixed rates faster than the RBA as funding costs bite

Australian lenders are raising fixed mortgage rates faster than the Reserve Bank is moving, with analysts warning the tightening economy could trigger a loss cycle for households and business. The RBA cash rate has been held at 4.35 percent since the unanimous August 11 decision. The Australian reported commentary that a November increase is "certainly on the cards."

TRADE-ECONOMY · WSJ

Warburg Pincus lifts Ingenia bid to \$1.5 billion

Warburg Pincus has made an improved *\$1.5 billion* offer for Australian land-lease community operator Ingenia, the Wall Street Journal reported, adding to a run of foreign private capital bids for listed Australian property assets.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

CSL signs rare-disease drug deal worth up to \$1.6 billion

CSL has struck a rare disease drug agreement with Swiss firm Alentis worth up to *\$1.6 billion*, Reuters reported, one of the larger outbound deals by an Australian listed company this quarter.

TRADE-ECONOMY · PNG POST-COURIER

Ok Tedi commits K50 million to PNG drought response

Ok Tedi Mining Limited has committed *K50 million* to drought relief and recovery across Papua New Guinea, backing the national government's response to the El Niño-induced drought. The commitment follows warnings that El Niño effects will diverge sharply across Pacific states into 2027.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji Airways to add 125,000 seats in 2027, including Western Sydney

Fiji Airways will add about *125,000* seats in 2027, launching services to Western Sydney and increasing flights to Hong Kong, Christchurch, Singapore, and Tokyo. Chief executive **Paul Scurrah** said the growth strengthens links to key markets; the airline does not expect to expand its fleet.

• UPCOMING

OCT
6

Albanese and Pacific leaders visit Tuvalu for the Pre-COP leaders' event

The visit tests whether Australia's COP31 negotiating role survives Pacific criticism of its coal approvals.

OCT
8

Pacific Pre-COP31 meeting closes in Nadi, with ministerial talks on finance access on Thursday

Fiji says the finance session will carry community evidence into the Antalya negotiating agenda.

OCT
19

WHO Regional Committee for the Western Pacific opens in Manila, with a Samoan health delegation attending

Samoa's cabinet approved the travel alongside a parliamentary delegation to Canberra.

NOV
2

Third reading of Fiji's Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026

The bill needs the support of 66 percent of MPs for the December 9 referendum to proceed.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election, advance voting from October 26

Determines whether the National, ACT, and NZ First coalition continues and who holds foreign affairs.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Fast-tracking Pacific survival: the push for an ex-post climate fund window

Kiribati's Minister for Women, Youth, Sport and Social Affairs **Ruth Cross Kwansing** argues for an ex-post climate finance window: build coastal defences first, seek reimbursement later. She writes as Pacific Islands Forum Political Champion for Gender Equality and Social Inclusion.

ISLANDS BUSINESS

French health delegation weighs referring Wallis and Futuna patients to Fiji

Dr **Yves Burckel**, who heads the emergency department at the main hospital in Wallis and Futuna, made a second visit to Pacific Specialist Healthcare in Nadi, exploring whether patients now referred to Australia or India could be treated within the region.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Why an EU "associate membership" is the wrong Canada story

The Interpreter argues the associate-membership label is noise, and that the substance is an economic security alliance Australia should watch closely.

LOWY INTERPRETER

Australia's missed moment on global LGBTQI+ rights

With LGBTQI+ rights retreating worldwide, the piece argues Australia's rejection at the UN squandered a chance to lead in the Asia-Pacific.

SMH

Young Australian caught up in IS could return home on a passport

Yusuf Zahab, 23, will not be prosecuted because he was a minor during the conflict, two sources told the Sydney Morning Herald, and could soon return to Australia on a passport.

AU-POLITICS

ABC

Megalogenis on the three shocks reshaping Australian politics

George Megalogenis, author of *Three Shocks: Who We Are Becoming in the 21st Century*, argues Australia's demographic shift from blue-collar to professional, Australian-born to migrant, inner city to suburb has outrun its politicians. Recorded at the Hawke Centre, Adelaide University, on August 20, 2026.

● ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Can Australia Create Lasting Climate Impacts For the Asia-Pacific?

The piece notes Australia presides over negotiations at COP31 in Türkiye and argues the durability of its regional climate support, not the summit itself, determines the outcome for Asia-Pacific partners.

Argument: Australia's COP31 negotiating presidency will be judged on whether its support for regional partners is sustained beyond the summit.

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AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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